

Imposition of Liberalism

Why do countries try to impose liberalism on other countries?

1. **Self-interest** - Goals that a country pursues for its benefit.
 - A justification is to eliminate or reduce terrorist threats or for economic reasons.
 - Historical examples of this imposition were seen after WWI with the Treaty of Versailles imposing democratic governments (Weimar Republic) as a condition of peace.
 - "Spreading democracy" has become the core of many American foreign policies ever since.
 - Proponents of imposing liberalism argue that this can have economic and security benefits. (Liberal nations are less likely to threaten each other)
 - **Examples:** George W. Bush's "War on Terror", the Afghanistan invasion by NATO, and the American invasion of Iraq (declared illegal by the UN).
2. **Humanitarianism** - Trying to improve other people's living conditions or trying to stop human rights violations.
 - A justification is that it is moral or ethical to help those who can't help themselves.
 - An ideology that advocates promoting human welfare.
 - Humanitarians try to improve the lives of others and reduce suffering by trying to **reform societies**.
 - Some non-liberal countries do not observe human rights and some just choose not to embrace liberalism. This differentiation is critical.
 - **Example:** Invasion of Afghanistan to displace the Taliban's unethical treatment of women.

Reactions to the imposing of liberalism

- The imposition of liberalism has been met with a variety of reactions from foreign countries.
- Democratic elections are often hailed by liberal political leaders as a prerequisite to peace and good governance.
- However, when they are held in unstable political climates, elections can sometimes exacerbate existing tensions.